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# Definiteness and Effectiveness of Women's Responses to Unwanted Sexual Advances: A Laboratory Investigation

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This study investigated factors that might mediate the occurrence of male sexual aggression in dating relationships. In Experiment 1, 33 female undergraduates role-played their refusal of unwanted sexual advances in dating situations that varied in the level of the woman's romantic interest in her date and in the intimacy level of the sexual activities. The results indicated that the definiteness of the nonverbal component of the women's responses did not vary across scenes. However, the women were found to be less verbally definite in situations in which they were romantically interested in their dates and in the low-intimacy situations. In Experiment 2, 58 male college students rated selected women's responses differing in verbal definiteness for their effectiveness in stopping unwanted sexual advances. Responses that were more verbally definite were rated as more effective at stopping the unwanted advances, regardless of the level of intimacy. Men rated the responses as more effective in stopping their own unwanted advances than in stopping most men's unwanted advances. It was concluded that women may decrease the likelihood of being victims of sexual aggression by being more verbally definite in refusing unwanted sexual advances. However, other factors may also influence whether sexual aggression occurs.

Documentation of the prevalence of sexual aggression within dating relationships (Byers & Eastman, 1979; Brickman & Briere, 1984; Kanin,

1969; Koss & Oros, 1982) recently has led theorists to reject explanations of sexual aggression based on the psychopathology of the offender. Rather, these theorists characterize sexual interactions in our society as generally coercive and see rape and sexual aggression as points along a continuum of coercive sexual interactions (Brownmiller, 1975; Clark & Lewis, 1977; Gager & Schurr, 1976).

These authors have suggested that sex-role socialization places men and women in adversarial positions with respect to sexual interaction. According to accepted patterns of interaction in sexual relationships, a woman's role is to grant only limited access to her sexuality in order to enhance her attractiveness to potential mates. A man's role, on the other hand, is to attempt to gain access to a woman's sexuality. Further, a man's use of coercive strategies to do so is tacitly condoned. This view has been supported by studies that have found that college women report using all strategies for avoiding sex more frequently than do college men, whereas college men report using all strategies for having sex more frequently than do college women (Laplane, McCormick, & Brannigan, 1980; McCormick, Brannigan, & Laplane, 1984). The potential for coercive sexual interactions is seen as being further increased by female socialization toward passivity (except in sexual situations), and by society's acceptance of rape supportive myths and interpersonal violence toward women (Burt, 1980).

Researchers have in fact found a high level of sexual aggression in dating relations—between 34% and 83% of women report having had sex against their will at least once in the past (Brickman & Briere, 1984; Byers & Eastman, 1979; Kanin & Parcell, 1977; Koss & Oros, 1982; Mynatt & Allgeier, 1985). However, contrary to depictions of sexual interactions as generally coercive, Byers and Lewis (1988) found that most sexual disagreement situations in which the man desires a higher level of sexual activity than does the woman do not result in male sexual aggression or coercion. Thus, other factors must mediate whether aggressive behavior occurs when couples disagree about the desired level of sexual activity. Wilson and Byers (1981) found, for example, that men's attitudes toward women's roles may influence their compliance in these situations. It is also possible that the woman's way of refusing the unwanted sexual advances influences whether the man uses a coercive strategy to "persuade" her to engage in the unwanted sexual behavior. If this is the case, it is also important to investigate how various factors affect women's behavior in sexual disagreement situations.

The purpose of the two studies reported here was to investigate (a) the effects of three variables that may relate to the occurrence of sexual aggression on the definiteness of women's refusals of unwanted sexual advances and (b) how the definiteness of women's responses relates to their effectiveness at stopping men's unwanted sexual advances.

## EXPERIMENT 1

Traditional sex roles prescribe that it is the woman's role to control sexual interactions by setting firm limits (Clark & Lewis, 1977). Although attitudes toward appropriate roles for women have been found to influence perceptions and attributions about rape (Klemmack & Klemmack, 1976), women adhering to a feminist ideology are no more or less likely than women with more traditional views to have experienced sexual or dating aggression (Korman & Leslie, 1982; Sigelman, Berry, & Wiles, 1984). The effects of sex-role ideology on women's behavior in sexual situations, however, has not been investigated directly.

Two opposing hypotheses may be put forward. Because women are traditionally socialized to be passive, traditional women might be expected to be more passive and less definite in their refusals of unwanted sexual advances. However, traditional sex roles dictate that it is the woman's responsibility to limit sexual activity. Further, a traditional woman might be more concerned about the effects on her reputation of risking her sexuality and thus might be quite definite in her refusals of sexual advances. Therefore, in the present study, it is hypothesized that women holding traditional sex-role beliefs would be more definite in their refusals of unwanted sexual advances than would women with a less traditional view of sex roles.

Traditional sex roles dictate not only that it is the woman's role to limit sexual activity but also that women risk their reputations and risk being disbelieved at higher levels of intimacy (Clark & Lewis, 1977). Thus, women are thought to take less offense to early sexual advances than to more coitally directed advances (Korman & Leslie, 1982). It would be expected that the more intimate the sexual activity, the more definite women would be in their refusals of unwanted sexual advances.

The third factor that was investigated was the woman's romantic interest in her date. Clark and Lewis (1977) suggested that women use their sexuality as a bargaining tool in maintaining men's romantic interest in them. To do so, women must take some risks with their sexuality while at the same time protecting their reputations. Consistent with this theory, Kanin (1969) found that women who were less emotionally involved with their dates tended to react more strongly in rejecting unwanted advances. In the present study, it was expected that the more romantically interested the women were in their dates, the less definite they would be in their refusals of the unwanted sexual advances.

The present study investigated the effects of women's sex-role ideology, the level of sexual intimacy, and the level of the woman's romantic interest in her date on the definiteness of women's refusals of unwanted sexual advances. Because direct observation of sexual interactions in either an *in*

*vivo* or analogue situation is impossible, the definiteness of the women's responses was determined experimentally using a modified role-play technique in which participants role-played their verbal behavior and described their nonverbal behavior. This technique has been used previously in studies investigating men's and women's behavior in sexual interactions (Byers, in press; Byers & Wilson, 1985). Role play has advantages over self-report in that it allows direct observation of at least some aspects of the communication process without interpretation by the subject, and it is not subject to bias due to faulty memory. However, role-play procedures are similar to self-report techniques in that they are subject to bias due to social desirability and perceived demand characteristics. Dating assertiveness in general and sexual experience were also assessed.

## Method

### *Participants*

Participants were 33 unmarried female undergraduate volunteers enrolled in an introductory psychology course at the University of New Brunswick. All participants received extra-credit points for their participation in this experiment. Participants ranged in age from 17 to 28 years, with a median of 19 years. All participants had dated at least twice during the month preceding the experiment.

### *Materials*

*Stimulus scenes.* Nine stimulus scenes describing dating situations were recorded on separate cassette tapes. Tapes varied on (a) the level of consensual sexual intimacy attained by the couple and the level of intimacy about which the couple disagreed (SI) and on (b) the degree of the woman's romantic interest in her date (RI). Three levels of sexual intimacy were used. These involved progression from necking to breast fondling (low SI), breast fondling to genital fondling (moderate SI), and genital fondling over the clothes to undressing (high SI). In each instance, the woman had consented to the lower level of sexual intimacy but was not in agreement to the higher level of intimacy desired by the man in the situation. Three levels of romantic interest (RI) were used. The woman in the scene was described as either not romantically interested (low RI), somewhat romantically interested (moderate RI), or very romantically interested (high RI) in her date.

All other background information on the tapes was held constant. The following is an example of the scenes and indicates low SI and low RI.

You and Tom have dated regularly for the last month. You enjoy Tom's company but are not romantically interested in him. The two of you have returned to your apartment after a date. Your roommate is out for the evening. You and Tom are sitting on the couch necking. You have done this before and both of you enjoyed it. Tom begins to fondle your breasts. You do not wish to do this with Tom. What do you say or do?

*Sex Role Ideology Scale (SRI).* The SRI is a 30-item self-report questionnaire assessing respondents' beliefs in traditional sex roles (Kalin & Tilby, 1978). Respondents indicate the degree of their agreement or disagreement with statements concerning appropriate behavior for men and women on a 7-point Likert scale, with high scores indicating a nontraditional position. Two items pertain to appropriate sexual behavior. The SRI has been shown to successfully discriminate between criterion groups of traditional and feminist women. Split-half reliabilities of .79 and .84 and test-retest reliability of .87 have been reported.

*Heterosexual Behavior Inventory (SBI).* The SBI (Bentler, 1968) consists of 21 statements that constitute a hierarchy of heterosexual behavior. A respondent's score is equal to the number of statements marked as behaviors in which she has engaged in the past. This scale has been shown to have good reliability (Bentler, 1968).

*Dating and Assertion Questionnaire (DAQ).* The DAQ (Levenson & Gottman, 1978) is an 18-item self-report measure of social competence in dating situations. The questionnaire assesses the probability of occurrence of certain dating behaviors and the expected degree of discomfort and incompetence in handling specific situations requiring assertive or dating skills. For each item, respondents indicate both the frequency with which the behavior occurs and their degree of discomfort with the behavior. The authors have shown that this questionnaire discriminates between client and nonclient groups and has good internal consistency (Cronbach alphas = .92 and .85 for the two subscales). However, because research has not supported the two-factor structure proposed by the authors (Garbin, Robertson, & Bernstein, 1986), only the total score was used.

*Postexperimental Questionnaire (PEQ).* Participants were asked to indicate postexperimentally which, if any, piece of information presented in the audiotaped scenes was most important in determining their responses. Subjects were also given the opportunity to describe what they believed was the purpose of the experiment.

### *Procedure*

There were two experimental sessions. The SRI was administered to participants in small groups in the first session after subjects had read and signed an informed consent form indicating their understanding of the procedure and willingness to participate in the second session. Eleven women were randomly selected from each of three groups based on a tertiary split of scores on the SRI as reported by Kalin and Tilby (1978) to form traditional, moderate, and feminist SRI groups. These women were contacted by telephone, and a time for the second session was arranged on an individual basis.

In the second session, participants were tested individually by an experimenter blind to the individual's SRI score. Participants were told that they would listen to tape recordings of several situations. They were told to imagine that they themselves were the woman in the situation and to then respond by saying what they would say and/or by describing what they would do in that situation. Although these instructions represent a modification of standard role-play instructions in that the women only described their nonverbal behavior, this procedure was used to gather some preliminary data on women's nonverbal behavior in disagreement situations. Further, in previous studies using the role-play procedure, subjects rated themselves as being confident that their role-played responses matched what their actual behavior would be in these situations (Byers & Wilson, 1985).

Prior to role-playing their responses to the experimental scenes, subjects practiced role playing by responding to training scenes describing nonsexual dating situations. Participants were then played the taped scenes in random order, and their verbal response and/or description of their nonverbal behavior was tape-recorded using a second tape recorder. Following their initial response to each scene, participants were prompted with "Is there anything else you would say or do?" Any further response was also tape-recorded. Participants were then given the SBI, the DAQ, and the PEQ to complete.

### *Response Scoring*

Participants' taped responses were scored for definiteness on separate scales measuring the definiteness of the verbal and nonverbal components of the responses (verbal definiteness and nonverbal definiteness) by raters blind to the experimental conditions. The rating categories were based on verbatim reportings of women's verbal and nonverbal responses in actual sexual disagreement situations (see Byers & Lewis, 1988) and are summarized in Tables 1 and 2. In making their ratings, raters used both the initial response as well as any response to the experimenter's prompt that was not

TABLE 1  
Average Frequencies of Women's Verbal Responses to Unwanted Sexual Advances  
for Each Level of Sexual Intimacy and Romantic Interest

| <i>Verbal Definiteness Rating Scale</i>                                                 | <i>Sexual Intimacy</i> |                   |                  | <i>Romantic Interest</i> |                  |                  | <i>Marginal</i> |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------|------------------|--------------------------|------------------|------------------|-----------------|
|                                                                                         | <i>Low</i>             | <i>Moderate</i>   | <i>High</i>      | <i>Low</i>               | <i>Moderate</i>  | <i>High</i>      |                 |
| 1. No clear verbal refusal                                                              | .24 <sub>ab</sub>      | .11 <sub>a</sub>  | .05 <sub>b</sub> | .08                      | .16              | .16              | .13             |
| 2. Refusal implying advances might be acceptable at some other time or place in present | .02                    | 0.00 <sub>c</sub> | .06 <sub>c</sub> | .05                      | .01              | .02              | .03             |
| 3. Refusal implying advances might be acceptable in future                              | .28                    | .27               | .31              | .16 <sub>de</sub>        | .32 <sub>d</sub> | .38 <sub>e</sub> | .29             |
| 4. Unqualified refusal                                                                  | .29 <sub>fg</sub>      | .48 <sub>f</sub>  | .41 <sub>g</sub> | .51 <sub>h</sub>         | .40              | .28 <sub>h</sub> | .39             |
| 5. Refusal with anger or threat that date leave                                         | .16                    | .15               | .13              | .20 <sub>i</sub>         | .10 <sub>i</sub> | .15              | .15             |

*Notes.* Each of the 33 participants responded to 9 scenes for a total of 297 responses. Means with the same subscript are significantly different using Tukey's ratio ( $p < .05$ ).

TABLE 2  
Average Frequencies of Women's Nonverbal  
Responses to Unwanted Sexual Advances

| <i>Nonverbal Definiteness Rating Scale</i>    |     |
|-----------------------------------------------|-----|
| 1. No physical refusal                        | .49 |
| 2. Blocked or did not perform sexual activity | .19 |
| 3. Moved away or pushed man away              | .12 |
| 4. Got up or slapped or hit man               | .19 |

*Note.* Each of the 33 participants responded to 9 scenes for a total of 297 responses.

conditional on the man's subsequent behavior (i.e., responses that followed "If he didn't stop, I would . . ." were not rated) and assigned a rating reflecting the most definite part of the response. For the purpose of assessing interrater agreement, the number of exact agreements was divided by the total number of scored responses calculated separately for verbal and nonverbal definiteness. The rates of agreement were 86% and 91%, respectively. Responses given different ratings by the two raters were rated by a third rater. The rating assigned by two of the three raters was then used for analysis.

## Results

Although most responses (92%) included a verbal component, only about half (51%) included a nonverbal component. However, virtually all re-



sponses included an unambiguous refusal (verbal and/or nonverbal) of the advances, indicating that respondents were in fact role-playing their unwillingness to engage in the behavior, as instructed.

### *Role-Played Refusals*

Because the data violated some assumptions of analysis of variance (ANOVA), the frequencies of the various levels on the Definiteness scales were subjected to two separate multivariate analyses of variance (MANOVAs). Four dummy variates were created to correspond to the 5-point scale used to rate verbal definiteness. These were analyzed by a  $3 \times 3 \times 3$  MANOVA (SRI  $\times$  SI  $\times$  RI) with the dummy variates as four dependent measures. SRI was analyzed as a between-subject variable; SI and RI were analyzed as within-subject variables. Low-, moderate-, and high-SRI groups had mean SRI scores of 114.1 ( $SD = 13.9$ ), 146.6 ( $SD = 4.9$ ), and 163.8 ( $SD = 10.4$ ), respectively. Nonverbal definiteness was analyzed using the same design with three dummy variates.

There were no significant effects for nonverbal definiteness. For verbal definiteness, however, significant multivariate main effects were found for both SI and RI,  $F(8, 23) = 3.43$  and  $3.80$ ,  $p < .001$ , respectively. Univariate analysis of the significant multivariate effects indicated that SI affected the frequencies of verbal definiteness ratings 1, 2, and 4 (see Table 1),  $F(2, 60) = 8.93$ ,  $3.18$ , and  $6.94$ ,  $p < .05$ , respectively. RI affected the frequencies of verbal definiteness ratings of 3, 4, and 5,  $F(2, 60) = 7.24$ ,  $5.52$ , and  $4.31$ ,  $p < .05$ , respectively.

The mean frequencies of verbal responses given for each SI and RI level are presented in Table 1. Tukey's ratio was used to compare means. Significantly more women made no verbal refusal (rating = 1) in the low-SI conditions than in either of the other SI conditions. Although this response was made relatively infrequently, participants were more likely to refuse while indicating that the advances might be acceptable at some other time or place (rating = 2) in the high-SI than in the moderate-SI conditions. Participants were less likely to give an unqualified refusal (rating = 4) in the low-SI conditions than in the other SI conditions.

Participants gave refusals indicating that the advance might be acceptable in the future (rating = 3) less frequently in the low-RI conditions than in the moderate- or high-RI conditions. The frequency of unqualified refusals (rating = 4) tended to decrease with increasing romantic interest, but only the difference between the low-RI and high-RI conditions reached significance. Finally, women were more likely to get angry in the low-RI than in the moderate-RI conditions.

### *Predicting Women's Responses From Their Characteristics*

To predict women's response from their characteristics, SBI, DAQ, and SRI scores were entered into two separate canonical correlations with the total frequency of each type of verbal definiteness and nonverbal definiteness response as the dependent measures. No significant functions were found in either analysis.

### *Postexperimental Questionnaire*

Participants were asked postexperimentally whether the level of sexual intimacy, the woman's romantic interest in her date, or some other information in the scenes most influenced their responses. The largest number of women (58%) reported that the woman's feelings about the man was most important. A further 27% identified the level of sexual intimacy as most important.

### *Discussion*

Both the level of sexual intimacy and the woman's level of romantic interest in her date were found to affect the definiteness of participants' verbal responses but not their nonverbal responses. However, the women's characteristics, including sexual experience, sex-role ideology, and general assertiveness in dating situations, were not related to the nature of either their verbal or nonverbal responses. This suggests that characteristics of the situation rather than of the women themselves have the most effect on women's behavior in sexual situations.

In general, the women's refusals of breast fondling were less definite than their refusals of genital fondling or undressing. Participants were less likely to make an unqualified refusal and conversely more likely to make no verbal refusal in response to unwanted breast fondling than to the higher intimacy activities. These latter activities can be seen as being coitally directed activities, supporting Korman and Leslie's (1982) suggestion that women take less offense to lower-level sexual advances than to coitally directed advances.

The women were also, in general, more verbally definite in response to scenes in which they were described as not romantically interested in their date as compared to those in which they were described as somewhat or very romantically interested. Kanin (1969) also found that women who were less emotionally involved with their dates tended to react more strongly in

rejecting unwanted sexual advances. Compared with women who had no romantic interest in their date, women who had some degree of romantic interest in their date were more likely to qualify their refusal by stating or implying that they might change their minds at some time in the future. Conversely, in these latter conditions, the women were less likely to give an unqualified refusal that did not include this possibility in their refusal. To determine whether this puts romantically interested women at greater risk for sexual aggression, it is important to ascertain how men respond to refusals when women include the possibility that they may change their minds in the future. In addition, in the conditions in which the woman was not romantically interested in her date, participants were more likely to give very strong refusals in which they got angry or asked their date to leave perhaps because, as Clark and Lewis (1977) suggested, in these conditions women would not be trying to use the possibility of future sexual interactions to maintain the man's romantic interest in them.

The definiteness of the nonverbal component of the women's responses did not vary across scenes. Examination of the women's responses indicated that almost half did not include a description of a nonverbal response. This is consistent with Byers's (1980) finding that only 24% of women ranked a nonverbal response as the most important way in which a woman indicates her nonconsent to sexual activity. However, although the frequencies of the various verbal responses were similar to those reported by Byers and Lewis (1988) for women's behavior in actual disagreement situations, these results are not consistent with their findings with respect to nonverbal behavior. Rather, Byers and Lewis found that most women described having used both verbal and nonverbal strategies in refusing unwanted advances. Thus, it may be that the role-play technique used was not effective at eliciting nonverbal behavior because the women only described rather than role-played what they would do. Further, the women may have omitted the more subtle nonverbal behaviors as well as automatic behaviors of which they are not aware. Thus, the results regarding the women's nonverbal behavior should be considered tentative. Further investigation of women's nonverbal behavior in disagreement situations is needed before conclusions can be drawn about the relative significance that men attach to the verbal and nonverbal components of women's refusals of unwanted sexual advances.

## EXPERIMENT 2

The practical significance of differences in definiteness across scenes is not known because the relationship between the definiteness of women's responses and the persistence of men's sexual advances has not been determined. It needs to be shown that less definite responses put women at

greater risk for sexual aggression. As a first step, a second experiment was conducted in which men were asked to rate women's responses varying in verbal definiteness for their effectiveness at stopping sexual advances. Although the relationship between effectiveness ratings and male behavior in actual disagreement situations is not known, preliminary research suggested that these ratings are sensitive to differences in women's refusals (Giles & Byers, 1982).

It has been suggested that sexual aggression is an act of overconforming to the male sex role requiring men to be aggressive in sexual situations (Clark & Lewis, 1977; Russell, 1975). Burt (1980) documented that rape-supportive myths, such as the myth that when a woman says "No" she means "Yes," are prevalent and are related both to sex-role ideology and to acceptance of interpersonal violence against women. She hypothesized that beliefs such as the acceptance of rape myths play a causal role in sexual aggression. Malamuth (1981) reported that high rape myth acceptance in men was related to greater aggressive behavior toward women in the laboratory. Thus, the present study investigated whether men with high rape myth acceptance (compared to men with low rape myth acceptance) would rate women's responses as less effective in stopping sexual advances.

A woman's willingness to engage in low intimacy sexual activities may be interpreted by men as consent to more intimate sexual activities. For example, nonresistance to breast and/or genital fondling may be interpreted as consent to intercourse (Byers, 1980; Schultz & DeSavage, 1975). In fact, male sexual aggression is frequently preceded by consensual sexual involvement at a less intimate level (Byers & Eastman, 1979; Kanin, 1969). Clark and Lewis (1977) suggested that the higher the level of consensual intimacy, the more likely the man is to assume that he has the right of sexual access to the woman and the less likely he is to take "No" for an answer. Therefore, the effects of intimacy level on men's ratings were also investigated.

The present study investigated the effects of verbal definiteness, men's acceptance of rape myths, and the level of sexual intimacy on men's ratings of women's responses to unwanted sexual advances in a dating situation. The men rated the effectiveness of these responses at stopping their own and most men's sexual advances.

## Method

### *Subjects*

Participants were 58 unmarried male undergraduate students enrolled in an introductory psychology course at the University of New Brunswick. All

subjects received extra-credit points for their voluntary participation in the experiment. Participants ranged in age from 17 to 25 years (median = 20 years).

### *Materials and Measures*

Two scenes corresponding to the scenes describing unwanted breast fondling and unwanted undressing (low SI and high SI) in Experiment 1 were transcribed onto file cards and were used as stimulus scenes in Experiment 2. The moderate-SI scene was not used because the women had responded similarly to the moderate- and high-SI scenes. These scenes were identical to those heard by the women in Experiment 1 with the exceptions that they were rewritten from the male's perspective and that the descriptions of the woman's romantic interest in her date were omitted. In addition, the statement "You want to have intercourse with her" was added to the high-SI scene to make it less ambiguous.

Responses given by the women in Experiment 1 were adapted for use in this study and were transcribed onto separate file cards. Responses were grouped as low, medium, or high in verbal definiteness (VD) according to their ratings on the Verbal Definiteness scale. Low-VD responses received ratings of 1 or 2; medium-VD responses received ratings of 3; high-VD responses received ratings of 4 or 5 (see Table 1). Six responses from each category that differed in their verbal wording were randomly selected. Three descriptions of the woman moving away from the man and three descriptions of the woman standing up (i.e., corresponding to nonverbal definiteness ratings of 3 and 4) were converted to the third person singular and were randomly assigned to one of the six verbal responses selected for each verbal definiteness category.

The following is an example of the scenes presented to the men indicating unwanted breast fondling as the level of unwanted intimacy and a low definite response from the woman.

You and Ann have dated regularly since you met at a party. The two of you have just been to a movie and have returned to Ann's apartment after the date. You find that Ann's roommate is out for the evening. You and Ann are sitting on the couch in Ann's living room. You begin necking. The two of you have done this before and both of you enjoyed it. You begin to fondle Ann's breasts. Ann moves away and says, "How many classes do you have tomorrow?"

Two 6-point scales were used to rate each response: (a) how effective the response would be in stopping the participant's own advances (self-effectiveness) and (b) how effective the response would be in stopping most

men's advances (other effectiveness). The following statements corresponded to each point on the Effectiveness scales: *Very ineffective. I/he would not stop* (1); *Ineffective. I/he probably would not stop* (2); *Slightly ineffective. I/he might not stop* (3); *Slightly effective. I/he might stop* (4); *Effective. I/he would probably stop* (5); *Very effective. I/he would stop immediately* (6).

The Rape Myth Acceptance Scale (RMA; Burt, 1980) is a 19-item scale measuring prejudicial, stereotyped, or false beliefs about rape, rape victims, and rapists. Responses to 11 items on the scale are recorded on a 7-point Likert scale. The remaining items use two different 5-point scales. Thus, scores range from 19 to 117. High scores indicate greater adherence to rape myths. This scale has been shown to have good reliability (Cronbach alpha = .88) and to be related to several other attitude variables (Burt, 1980).

### *Procedure*

Male students who had not participated in a related experiment were randomly selected from the introductory psychology subject pool. They were contacted by telephone and were asked to participate in a study of factors affecting behavior in sexual dating situations. Volunteers received extra credit for their participation.

The men were tested in small groups. Following obtaining informed consent, subjects were given one of the stimulus scenes (low or high SI) and a deck of file cards containing the women's responses arranged in a different random order for each subject. Participants were instructed to read the description of the dating situation and to imagine that they themselves were the man in the situation. They then rated each of the 18 responses in turn on the two rating scales. Upon completing all the ratings, participants completed the RMA followed by a postexperimental questionnaire and a scale not relevant to this study. A review of the items on the PEQ indicated that respondents were not aware of the purpose of the study and had not participated in related studies.

### *Results*

To determine the relationship between (a) verbal definiteness, RMA, and sexual intimacy and (b) the men's ratings of the effectiveness of these responses at stopping their own and most men's sexual advances, self-effectiveness and other effectiveness ratings were subjected to a  $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 2$  ANOVA. RMA and SI were analyzed as between-subjects factors; VD and Target (Self-Effectiveness, Other Effectiveness) were analyzed as

repeated factors. High- and low-RMA groups were created using a median split (median = 43.5,  $M = 42.9$ ,  $SD = 8.8$ ).

Results of the ANOVA indicated a main effect for target and for VD,  $F(1, 108) = 97.78$ ,  $p < .001$  and  $F(2, 108) = 203.49$ ,  $p < .001$ , respectively. In addition, there were significant VD  $\times$  SI and VD  $\times$  Target interactions,  $F(2, 108) = 8.25$ ,  $p < .001$  and  $F(2, 108) = 3.87$ ,  $p < .05$ , respectively. Due to unequal cell sizes, a Scheffé procedure was used to compare means. (See Table 3 for the interaction means.)

Effectiveness ratings increased across levels of low, medium, and high VD, which all differed significantly from one another ( $M$ s = 3.4, 4.5, and 4.9, respectively). This was true both for subjects who responded to the low-SI scenes and for those who responded to the high-SI scenes, as well as for both self-effectiveness and other effectiveness ratings. SI affected ratings of the effectiveness of low-VD responses but not the medium- or high-VD responses. Men rated the low-VD responses as more effective in the low-SI than the high-SI scenes.

Subjects rated the women's responses as significantly more effective in stopping their own sexual advances ( $M = 4.6$ ) than in stopping most men's sexual advances ( $M = 3.9$ ). This was true for their ratings of the low-, medium-, and high-VD responses.

## Discussion

More verbally definite responses were rated as more effective at stopping the unwanted sexual advances. This provides some validity for the Verbal Definiteness scale and the results of Experiment 1. Further, it is consistent with Byers's (1980) finding that the majority of male subjects ranked a

TABLE 3  
Men's Average Effectiveness Ratings as a Function of Experimental Conditions and Target

| Condition                                    | Verbal Definiteness |                   |                   |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
|                                              | Low                 | Medium            | High              |
| Sexual Intimacy $\times$ Verbal Definiteness |                     |                   |                   |
| Low intimacy                                 | 3.7 <sub>ac</sub>   | 4.4 <sub>a</sub>  | 4.9 <sub>a</sub>  |
| High intimacy                                | 3.2 <sub>bc</sub>   | 4.5 <sub>b</sub>  | 5.0 <sub>b</sub>  |
| Target $\times$ Verbal Definiteness          |                     |                   |                   |
| Self-effectiveness                           | 3.8 <sub>df</sub>   | 4.8 <sub>dg</sub> | 5.2 <sub>dh</sub> |
| Other effectiveness                          | 3.1 <sub>ef</sub>   | 4.1 <sub>eg</sub> | 4.6 <sub>eh</sub> |

*Note.* The 58 participants rated responses at all three verbal definiteness levels. Means with the same subscript differ significantly from each other using the Scheffé procedure ( $p < .05$ ).

verbal refusal as the clearest and most important way that a woman communicates her nonconsent to sexual activities. However, it is not known how closely ratings of effectiveness correspond to how men would actually behave in this type of disagreement situation. Thus, future research needs to determine whether men are in fact more likely to persist with unwanted advances when women give less definite verbal responses. The present results, however, do suggest that women who give low definite verbal refusals of unwanted sexual advances may be at risk for experiencing sexual coercion.

Despite the fact that all verbal responses were paired with fairly definite nonverbal responses, the men's ratings indicated that they were not certain that even the most verbally definite responses would stop unwanted sexual advances. This is consistent with descriptions of sexual interactions as adversarial (Clark & Lewis, 1977) and with previous research on men's role-play behavior in sexual disagreement situations (Byers & Eastman, 1979; Byers & Wilson, 1985).

Only limited support was found for the suggestion that the level of sexual intimacy would affect men's ratings of response effectiveness. Verbal definiteness affected men's ratings in both the unwanted breast fondling and unwanted intercourse conditions. Thus, consistent with previous research (Byers & Wilson, 1985), these data do not support Clark and Lewis's (1977) suggestion that the level of intimacy is a more important determinant of men's behavior than what the woman says because women are seen as forfeiting their right to say "No" beyond a certain level of consensual intimacy. However, low definiteness responses were rated as less effective in the high-intimacy than in the low-intimacy condition. Thus, it may be that nonassertive refusals are more likely to be disbelieved in high-intimacy situations, perhaps because the man believes that this indicates that the woman "really" means "Yes."

Participants consistently rated the women's responses as being more effective in stopping their own advances than in stopping most men's sexual advances. This is consistent with findings by Driscoll and Davis (1976) that men rate themselves as being less sexually aggressive than their same-sex peers. This probably was due to social desirability factors. However, it may also be because the men believed the sex-role stereotype of the sexually aggressive male (Brownmiller, 1975; Clark & Lewis, 1977).

## GENERAL DISCUSSION

Some caution is needed in interpreting the results of the present studies. Both studies used within-subject methodologies. Although the orders of stimuli were randomized in both studies, this procedure may have sensitized



participants to the experimental variables. In addition, participants may have perceived a need to give different responses to the different stimulus scenes (Experiment 1) or different responses (Experiment 2). Thus, these differences might not correspond to differences in behavior in real sexual dating situations. Further, this design has more power to detect small differences than does a strictly factorial design. A replication of these results using a between-subject methodology is needed to rule out these possibilities. Nevertheless, these results do suggest that communication between dating men and women may contribute to male sexual aggression.

The definiteness of women's verbal refusals of unwanted sexual advances was affected by both the sexual intimacy of the situation and the woman's romantic interest in her date. Further, responses that were less verbally definite were rated by men as being less effective in stopping sexual advances. Although it is not known how the effectiveness ratings correspond to men's behavior in similar but real-life situations, these results suggest that indefinite refusals by women may place them at greater risk for becoming victims of sexual aggression. Low-intimacy situations as well as situations in which the women are romantically interested in their dates are most likely to produce less definite refusals and thus would put women at the greatest risk. Kanin (1969) also suggested that the woman's emotional involvement with her date may increase her sexual exploitability. The moderating effect of the man's romantic interest in the woman is yet to be determined.

The definiteness of women's verbal refusals of unwanted sexual advances may be one contributing factor to male sexual aggression. However, that even the high verbally definite responses were not rated as definitely stopping either the participant's own or most men's advances indicates that this may not be the only factor in sexual aggression. At a minimum, women's nonverbal behavior, as well as men's sexual scripts or stereotyped response patterns (Byers & Wilson, 1985), may influence how men react to any response a woman may make in this situation, regardless of how definite it is. Surprisingly, rape myth acceptance was not related to rated effectiveness, perhaps because the two RMA groups were not sufficiently distinct due to a limited range of scores.

In summary, the present studies represent one methodology by which the sexual communication process may be studied. Future research needs to consider other factors that may contribute to the breakdown in communication and to the occurrence of male sexual aggression.

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